

Letter of Queen Violant de Bar to the Archbishop of Tarragona, confirming a canonry held by Bartholomeus Ponci — Barcelona, 1 June 1387

Document Summary

Field	Detail
Archive	Arxiu de la Corona d'Aragó (ACA), Cancillería, registre (f. 29v)
Date	1 June 1387 (<i>prima die Junii, anno a nativitate Domini M^o CCC^o LXXX^o VII^o</i>)
Place of issue	Barcelona (<i>Datum Barchinone</i>)
Issuing authority	Queen Violant de Bar (subscribed <i>Domina regina</i> ; the eschatocol's <i>iussio</i> runs in her name)
Recipient (<i>directio</i>)	The Archbishop of Tarragona (<i>Dirigitur Archiepiscopo Terracone</i>)
Document type	<i>Lletra missiva</i> of intercession — a <i>littera deprecatoria/commendaticia</i> asking the archbishop to confirm, or newly grant, a canonry
Beneficiary	Bartholomeus Ponci (Bartomeu Ponç[?]), canon, in connection with a monastery/house <i>de Stornalbou</i> [?]
Seal	<i>sub nostro sigillo secreto</i> — the queen's secret seal (<i>segell secret</i>)
Chancery order (<i>iussio</i>)	<i>Domina regina mandavit mihi</i> — i.e. dictated to the subscribing secretary (per the lower-right subscription, Bartholomeus Sirvent)

This is a queen's intercession letter on behalf of a cleric, **Bartholomeus Ponci**, who has held a canonry "*de Stornalbou*"¹ for some years at the king's request, and whose tenure the queen now asks the metropolitan to secure by confirmation or fresh provision. The interest of the piece is diplomatic and political: Violant intercedes in an ecclesiastical-patronage matter that originated *ad preces dicti domini regis et reginae* (at the joint request of king and queen), yet issues the present letter in her own name and under her own secret seal, through a chancery scribe of the king's writing-office.

Reconciled Transcription

Orthography preserved as written; standard suspensions expanded silently; genuinely uncertain readings marked [?]; editorial expansions and notes in square brackets. Line numbers editorial.

1. Rev[eren]de pater. D[omi]n[u]s rex, d[omi]n[u]s marit[us] et d[omi]ne² n[oste]r carissim[us], vob[is] scribitur³ super co[n]firma[ci]one [et] nova
2. p[ro]visione per vos fienda Bartholomeo Ponci⁴ canonico⁵ [Monasterii?] [?] de Stornalbou⁶ de Cantu⁷ [?], eode[m]
3. q[uo]d ex [vestra?] [?] d[i]c[t]i p[ro]vide[n]c[i]a [vestr]e e[ss]et f[a]c[tu]m ad p[re]ces d[i]c[t]i d[omi]ni regis et r[egi]ne, Bartholomeo p[re]d[i]c[t]o, q[uo]d
4. obtinuit [et] iam per quinque annos possedit et possidet, prout in lo[r]is⁸ d[i]c[t]i d[omi]ni regi[ne]⁹ poteritis¹⁰
5. Iarius¹¹ intueri. Cumque p[ro]p[te]r[ea] novu[m] foret expedie[n]s, et nos per [con]seque[n]s affecte[mus]
6. non parum [inmoti?] [?] ex d[i]c[t]is n[ost]ris [obsequiis?] [?] per p[re]fatum Bartholomeum [prestis?] [?], rex eiusd[e]m m[ul]tu[m]
7. comendandis¹²; necnon ut stabilia maneant que sunt precibus n[ost]ris optenta¹³, q[uo]d fiat /
8. confirma[ci]o p[re]dicta [sive?] nova p[ro]visio sup[ra]d[i]c[t]a / vob[is], q[uo]d d[i]c[t]i d[omi]ni regis [benevolentie?] [?]
9. atq[ue] n[ost]ris no[m]in[i]b[us], [se]d m[ul]to plus d[i]c[t]o, p[ro]p[ter] [vestr]am d[i]c[t]am lib[er]alem et propriu[m]
10. affectu[m], rogam[us] quat[enus] confirma[ci]one[m] seu nova[m] p[ro]visione[m] iam d[i]c[t]am / velitis ob
11. reverentia[m] d[i]c[t]i d[omi]ni regis et n[ost]ri generi¹⁴ facere cu[m] effectu / Scietis q[uo]d ip[s]i d[omi]no regi
12. et nob[is] gratu[m] accidet / q[uo]d contrariu[m] difficil[ite]r ferem[us], dampnu[m] tam ex
13. desup[er] enarratis¹⁵ quanda[m]¹⁶ etiam g[?] esset valde absurdu[m], q[uo]d Bartholomeus p[re]d[i]c[t]us, si qui¹⁷
14. sub opte[?]cum¹⁸ cantu iam d[u]du[m] h[uius?]u[?] et p[ro]fessione[m] assumpsit et illum possedit /
15. ta[m]qu[am] dep[re]da[tu]r¹⁹ [?] n[ost]ro canonicat[u] eode[m]. Datum Barch[i]none sub n[ost]ro sigillo secreto, p[ri]ma
16. die Junij / anno a nativitate D[omi]ni M^o CCC^o LXXX^o VII^o / [Comitissa?]²⁰

Directio (lower-left margin): Dirig[itur] Archiep[iscop]o T[er]racone.

Iussio (lower-right subscription, two lines):

- *Domina regina mandavit mihi*²¹
 - *Barth[olomeus] Sirvent*²²
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Translation

Reverend Father.²³ The lord king — [my] lord and husband, and our most dear lord — writes³ to you concerning the confirmation and new provision to be made by you for Bartholomeus Ponci, canon of [the monastery?] of Stornalbou *de Cantu* [?],⁶ [in the matter of] the same [canonry?], which by [your?] foresight [?] in the aforesaid [matter] was, at your hand, made²⁴ at the request of the said lord king and queen to the aforesaid Bartholomeus — which he obtained and has now held and holds for five years, as you will be able to examine more fully¹¹ in the letters⁸ of the said lord [king/queen].²

And since on this account [a fresh act] would be expedient, and we in consequence are moved²⁵ — being not a little [stirred?] by the said services [rendered?] to us by the aforesaid Bartholomeus,²⁶ [a man] greatly to be commended;¹² and moreover, that those things may stand firm which have been obtained at our entreaty,¹³ — [we ask] that the aforesaid confirmation, or the new provision described above, be made: for you [to do so], [as touching] the goodwill[?] of the said lord king and [the matters carried out] in our names, but much more [as touching] the aforesaid [canonry], on account of your said liberal and proper disposition²⁷ — we ask that you be willing to carry out, in effect, the confirmation or the new provision already mentioned, out of reverence for the said lord king and for our son-in-law.¹⁴

You shall know that it will be agreeable to the lord king himself and to us; and that we would bear ill²⁸ the contrary, [namely] the loss, both from the matters set out above¹⁵ — [in] which, moreover, it would be quite absurd¹⁶ that the aforesaid Bartholomeus, who¹⁷ [...] under [...] ¹⁸ with the canonry [?] long since took up [this?] and the profession,²⁹ and has possessed it — [should suffer] as though he were despoiled¹⁹ of our canonry, the same [one].

Given at Barcelona under our secret seal,³⁰ on the first day of June, in the year from the Nativity of the Lord 1387. [The Countess?]²⁰

Directio: Addressed to the Archbishop of Tarragona. *Iussio*: The lady queen ordered [this] to me. — Bartholomeus Sirvent.

Footnotes

Unresolved Ambiguities (flagged for archival verification)

1. **The toponym/house *de Stornalbou* (l. 2) and its qualifier *de Cantu* [?] (l. 2).** The initial *St*-reading is secure, but the house is unidentified, the conjectured *Monasterii* expansion is provisional, and the trailing *de Can*— suspension (*Cantu*?) is not resolved. Check against the surrounding folios of the register and against known religious houses of the Tarragona province.
 2. ***in lo[r]is* (l. 4).** Almost certainly conceals *litteris* ("in the letters"), as the translation assumes, but the graphic as written is *loris*. Verify against the manuscript whether this is a scribal abbreviation of *litteris*, an error, or a genuine word. (The competing HTR reading *extra portas* is rejected.)
 3. ***domini regi[s] vs regine* (l. 4).** Whether the "letters" referred to are the king's or the queen's is undecided; affects whether the prior documentary trail runs through the king's or queen's chancery.
 4. **Lines 13–14 (*quandam etiam g[?] ... sub opte[?]cum ... si qui ...*).** The syntax is rough and several words (notes 16–18) are insecure. The overall rhetorical sense (the "absurdity" of despoiling a long-professed holder) is recoverable, but the precise wording is not. Priority passage for autopsy of the original.
 5. ***nostri generi* (l. 11) — the queen's "son-in-law."** Who is the *gener* invoked here, and what is his connection to the Stornalbou canonry? Prosopographical follow-up warranted; potentially relevant to the queen's patronage network.
 6. **The closing *Comitissa* [?] (l. 16).** Its function — part of the eschatocol, a chancery note, or a registration annotation — is unclear given the *Domina regina iussio*. Verify placement and hand against the original.
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Note on dissertation relevance

The eschatocol gives a clean, datable instance of **Violant de Bar exercising intercessory authority in her own name and under her own secret seal**, in a matter that originated jointly with the king (*ad preces dicti domini regis et reginae*) and is routed through a king's-chancery scribe (*Bartholomeus Sirvent*) who records the order as dictated to him personally (*mandavit mihi*). The dual framing — the king "writes" (l. 1) yet the queen commands and seals (ll. 15, *iussio*) — is exactly the kind of overlapping king/queen agency in ecclesiastical patronage that bears on the political-authority strand of the argument. The invocation of the queen's *gener* (note 14) further situates the request within her affinal network.

1. *Stornalbou*: the place/house designation is paleographically secure as written (initial *St*-, see footnote 6) but not yet identified prosopographically. It is plausibly a religious house in the ecclesiastical province of Tarragona, consonant with the metropolitan addressee. Carried to the unresolved-ambiguities section. ↵

2. *domine* (= *domini*, gen. sing.) here functioning within the queen's circumlocution for the king (*dominus maritus ... dominus noster carissimus*). The shift between nominative apposition (*dominus rex*, *dominus maritus*) and *dominus noster carissimus* is loose but unambiguous in sense: the queen designates her husband the king. ↵
3. *scribitur*: read with the -*tur* suspension. An earlier HTR witness gave *petiit*; the manuscript does not support it. The passive *vobis scribitur* ("it is written to you" / "[the king] writes to you") is the correct reading and resolves the opening protocol. ↵ ↵²
4. *Ponci*: the beneficiary's surname, read on the manuscript as **Ponci** (vernacular *Ponç*). An HTR witness gave the spurious *porte*; rejected. Confirmed on re-examination of the line-2 crop. ↵
5. *canonico*: dative, governed by *fienda ... Bartholomeo ... canonico*. The earlier HTR's nominative *canonicus* is grammatically impossible here and is a smoothing error. ↵
6. *de Stornalbou*: the toponym is read with initial *St-* (the long-s + *t* ligature is visible), against the alternative *Gornalbou* entertained at Stage 1. The word preceding it carries a suspension consistent with *Monasterii* ("of the monastery of ..."), though the expansion is offered tentatively. Both the house's identity and the *Monasterii* expansion are flagged below. ↵ ↵²
7. *de Cantu* [?]: the trailing *de Can*— with a superscript suspension (resolved provisionally *Cantu*) is uncertain. It may qualify the foregoing toponym or introduce *canonicatus*. Unresolved. ↵
8. *in lo[r]is*: the reading adopted from your collation (*prout in loris*). *loris* is anomalous; it most likely conceals *litteris* ("in the letters") via a heavily abbreviated or eye-skipped form, which is how the translation renders it. The bare graphic *loris* is retained in the transcription with the functional sense flagged. An earlier HTR fabricated *extra portas* here; that reading is rejected outright — there are no extramural gates in this clause. ↵ ↵²
9. *domini regi[ne]*: the manuscript wavers between *regis* and *regine* at this point; given the immediately preceding *dicti domini*, either "of the said lord king" or "of the said lady queen" is defensible. Left unresolved. ↵ ↵²
10. *poteritis*: 2nd pl. fut. ("you will be able"), addressed to the archbishop. Reading adopted from your collation. ↵
11. *larius* (= *latius* / *clarius*): "more fully / more clearly." The *t/r* ambiguity is characteristic; *latius intueri* ("to examine more fully") is the expected formula and is followed in the translation. ↵ ↵²
12. *comendandis*: gerundive, "to be commended." The earlier HTR's *commendatis* (and its incoherent *nemo ... maneat* in the next clause) are rejected. The construction is loose but the sense — Bartholomeus as a man worthy of commendation — is clear. ↵ ↵²
13. *ut stabilia maneant que sunt precibus nostris optenta*: "that those things may remain firm which have been obtained at our entreaty." This clause, which neither prior HTR witness could parse (one fabricated *nemo ut predicta maneat*), is the syntactic spine of the queen's request and is now secure. *optenta* = *obtenta*. ↵ ↵²

14. *nostri generi*: "our son-in-law" (*gener*, gen. *generi*). This is prosopographically significant: the queen frames the request partly *ob reverentiam ... nostri generi*, i.e. out of regard for a son-in-law. The identity of the son-in-law (and how he bears on a Tarragona canonry) is not stated and is flagged below. ↵ ↵²
15. *desuper enarratis*: "from the matters set out above." Reading adopted from your collation; resolves the earlier HTR's garbled *dictis enarracio*. ↵ ↵²
16. *quandam etiam ... esset valde absurdum*: the syntax of lines 13–14 is genuinely rough in the manuscript, and the construction does not fully resolve. The sense is recoverable — it would be "quite absurd" for Bartholomeus, a long-standing and duly professed holder, to be treated as if despoiled — but the connective tissue (*quandam etiam g[?]*) is not securely read. Flagged. ↵ ↵²
17. *si qui* [?]: uncertain. Possibly *si quis* or a relative construction; the translation leaves it open. ↵ ↵²
18. *sub opte[?]cum* [?]: not securely read; the *opt-* stem may relate to *optimo* ("under the best [title]?") as an earlier HTR guessed (*sub optimo canonicatus*), but the manuscript does not clearly support that expansion. Left unresolved. ↵ ↵²
19. *tamquam depredatur*: "as though he is despoiled/plundered." *depredatur* (dep.) carries the legal-rhetorical force of unjust dispossession — the rhetorical climax of the queen's argument. The reading is plausible but the surrounding clause (notes 16–18) is insecure. ↵ ↵²
20. *Comitissa* [?]: the single word closing line 16 was read at Stage 1 as *Comitissa* ("the Countess"). It does not sit easily beside *Domina regina* in the *iussio*; it may instead be a chancery annotation or a registration note rather than part of the eschatocol proper. Flagged. ↵ ↵²
21. *Domina regina mandavit mihi*: "The lady queen ordered [this] to me." Per your reading, the full first line of the *iussio* ends *mihi* — i.e. the secretary records that the queen dictated the letter to him personally. This is the standard *iussio* formula in the first person, the subscribing scribe being named immediately below. ↵
22. *Bartholomeus Sirvent*: the subscribing chancery scribe, a known figure of the Aragonese writing-office in this period. His appearance on a letter issued *Domina regina mandavit* places him drafting for the queen here, not (or not only) the king. ↵
23. *Reverende pater*: the *inscriptio*/salutation appropriate to a metropolitan archbishop, consistent with the *directio* to Tarragona. ↵
24. The relative clause of lines 2–3 (*quod ex ... providencia ... esset factum ad preces ...*) is syntactically loose in the original; the translation renders the recoverable sense (the grant having been made at the joint petition of king and queen) while the precise reading of *ex [vestra?] ... providencia* remains uncertain. ↵
25. *affectemus*: "we are disposed / moved [to act]." 1st pl. subj., the queen's *pluralis maiestatis*. ↵

26. Lines 5-6 (*non parum [inmoti?] ... per prefatum Bartholomeum [prestitis?]*) describe the queen as moved by services rendered to her by Bartholomeus, but the key words *inmoti* and *prestitis* are reconstructions of an abraded passage, not secure readings. The sense is formulaic and likely correct; the wording is flagged. ↵
27. *liberalem et proprium affectum*: "liberal and proper disposition" — the archbishop's own generous inclination, which the queen invokes as the principal ground (*multo plus dicto*) for action. ↵
28. *difficiliter feremus*: "we would bear with difficulty" → idiomatically "we would take ill / be displeased by." A diplomatic understatement-formula; the functional force is a veiled expression of royal displeasure at non-compliance. ↵
29. *professionem assumpsit*: "took up the profession" — i.e. made religious profession. This, with *iamdudum* ("long since"), grounds the argument that Bartholomeus is a long-established, duly professed holder whose dispossession would be unjust. ↵
30. *sigillum secretum* (*segell secret*): the queen's secret seal, distinct from the *sigillum parvum* (*petit anell*) conjectured at Stage 1. The choice of seal is diplomatically meaningful: secret-seal letters are the queen's more personal, less formal instrument of command. ↵